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International Investigations Editor

The New York Times

Dear Editor,

I am applying for the Open Source Intelligence Reporter role on the International Investigations team. The job description reads like a list of the things I have spent the last six years doing inside Al Jazeera's Investigative Unit — satellite imagery analysis, geolocation, vessel and aircraft tracking, large confidential datasets, all stitched together with traditional reporting. I would like to bring that toolkit to the Times.

Two recent pieces of mine show the range. *Africa's Ghost Reporters* (March 2025) traced a Russia-linked influence campaign that planted hundreds of paid-for articles across Francophone Africa under the bylines of more than 15 fictitious journalists. I identified the dead Central African teacher whose photo had been stolen to build the lead persona, pulled Cyrillic strings and a Russian phone number out of Word-document metadata, and reverse-traced the number to a former Internet Research Agency operator with Wagner ties. *The Island of Secrets* (IRE Award, 2021) reconstructed India's covert military build-out on the tiny Mauritian atoll of Agaléga from commercial satellite imagery, shipping data and on-island sourcing — a story a major government had wanted to keep buried. I have applied similar techniques inside the I-Unit on *All the Prime Minister's Men*, *The Cyprus Papers*, *The Men Who Sell Football* and *Diplomats for Sale*.

Below are three quick sketches of the kind of story I would chase from day one. They are angles, not pitches — meant to give you a sense of what I gravitate toward and how I would approach it.

THREE SKETCHES

1. The Russian shadow fleet, mapped end-to-end

Iran and Russia keep oil flowing through tankers that go dark, switch flags and meet in international waters. I would build a continuously updated dataset of AIS gaps, paired with satellite tasking around known ship-to-ship transfer zones (the Laconian Gulf, the Strait of Hormuz, the South China Sea), and connect the dots to the EU and Gulf ports quietly hosting the support infrastructure — bunkering services, P&I cover, beneficial owners hidden behind one-ship companies in Marshall Islands or Seychelles. This is the Agaléga methodology scaled up — and the Ghost Reporters work taught me how to follow Russian networks across the messier digital surface that always accompanies them.

2. Gaza, after the cameras leave

Once active fighting recedes, the satellite record becomes the only honest witness to what was destroyed, what was rebuilt, and what was never rebuilt. I would systematically compare pre-war, wartime and post-war imagery — schools, hospitals, water infrastructure, press buildings — and pair that with chronolocated open-source footage to test the official accounts of specific strikes. Quiet, methodical, accountability-first reporting that does not depend on access.

3. China's next Agaléga

India is not the only state quietly turning small islands into forward bases. China's footprint in Djibouti, the Solomons and across the Indian Ocean has been touched on but never fully reconstructed in a way Western readers can see. I would apply the Agaléga method — dual-use civilian projects that are obviously not civilian when you overlay the satellite, shipping and personnel-movement data — to one or two locations where the public record is thinnest.

WHAT I WOULD BRING

- All five minimum qualifications — OSINT, geolocation, chronolocation, satellite imagery, strong communication and a collaborative spirit — with award-recognised work behind each.
- Maritime and aviation traffic analysis as a routine working method, not an occasional flourish.

- Comfort with large, messy, leaked datasets, and with the source-protection discipline that comes with handling them.
- Visual-investigation instincts honed in a unit that ships in text, long-form video and interactive formats.
- Custom tooling. I build editorial scrapers and monitors using AI-assisted coding workflows (Claude Code, Gemini CLI), which lets a one-person investigation run at the scale of a small engineering team — useful for the kind of always-on tracking the shadow-fleet sketch above would need.
- EU citizenship and a willingness to relocate to whichever European bureau makes most sense for the team.

I would be genuinely glad to talk further, and to surprise you with what I would chase first. Thank you for considering my application.

Sincerely,

Yarno Ritzen